Unit 6. What is the gospel? (Reflection)

Overview

God's gospel is the central theme of 2 Timothy 1:8-12, which we encountered. This explores the important question of the nature of that gospel. It does so through three steps: encounter, reflection and action. These steps examine our own understandings, revisit 2 Timothy 1:8-12, reflect more widely on the gospel in the Pastoral Epistles, and begin to consider what this means in practice.

Outline

- Introduction
- Encounter your own understanding of the gospel
- Reflect on the meaning of the gospel in the Pastoral Epistles
- Action to take from a true understanding of the gospel

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Reflect independently on issues you meet in the Pastoral Epistles
2. Evaluate your own understanding of the gospel
3. Explain what the gospel is to other church leaders

6.1 INTRODUCTION

We have met the word 'gospel' a number of times in the preceding units and have seen its central importance in the Pastoral Epistles. These letters are all about "the importance of being a true teacher of God's message, the gospel, and the need to establish other true teachers of the faith."

We have just encountered 2 Timothy 1:8-12 and its emphasis on the gospel. This unit builds on that with some guided reflection. It does this through questions and discussion. The questions are given below and your Trainer will guide you through the process in three steps of encounter, reflection and action.

6.2 ENCOUNTER YOUR OWN UNDERSTANDING OF THE GOSPEL

We have just encountered 2 Timothy 1:8-12 and the gospel it contains. Some people assume that they are Christians but they have not understood the gospel and it has no impact on their lives. And genuine believers have different understandings of the gospel.

Before we look again at what the Pastoral Epistles say about the gospel, we need to be honest about our own understanding or lack of understanding of the gospel. Use the questions and guidelines below on your own, with another person or in a group reveal your thinking.

If you do this exercise in a pair, work through the questions one at a time allowing time for feedback. You can check whether you have understood your companion correctly by reflecting back their answer to them: "So you are saying that...?" This approach will make their answers clearer and improve your listening skills.

1. What do you think the word ‘gospel’ means?

2. Give a short summary and explanation of the gospel as you understand it.

3. Comment on the importance of the gospel to you. What difference has the good news made in your own life?

4. Comment on what the gospel seems to mean to other church leaders. Why do you think there are these different understandings?

6.3 REFLECT ON THE MEANING OF THE GOSPEL IN THE PASTORAL EPISTLES

We have thought about our understanding of the gospel. But what does Paul think?

6.3.1 Explore Paul’s understanding of the gospel in the Pastoral Epistles

Use the questions and guidelines below, beginning each time with 2 Timothy 1:8-14, before broadening out your investigation.

1. What words and phrases does Paul use for the gospel?
Discuss the words and phrases Paul uses in place of or to mean the same thing as "the gospel."

- Begin with 2 Timothy 1:8-14. What words or phrases does Paul use to refer to the gospel?

Extra: 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus are rich in words and phrases that describe the gospel. If you have time skim through the books and look for such words with your trainer's help.

2. What is the focus of the gospel?
- Discuss what 2 Timothy 1:8-14 tell us about what lies at the heart of the gospel.

Extra: Look at some or all of these texts: 1 Timothy 2:3-7; Titus 2:11-14 and 3:3-8.

3. What is the foundation of the gospel?
- Discuss what 2 Timothy 1:8-14 tell us about who or what lies behind the gospel.

4. What is the fruit of the gospel?
- Discuss what 2 Timothy 1:8-14 tell us about what the gospel produces.

5. How does the gospel relate to time: the past, present and future?
- Finally, look at Titus 2:11-14 and Titus 3:3-8 and discuss how we are to think about the past, present and future in the light of the gospel.

6.3.2 Pulling our findings together

Use the questions below to summarise your discoveries.

What is the gospel?

Who is involved in the gospel?

Why is there a gospel at all?

How has the gospel been implemented, in history and in our lives?

When does the gospel have an impact?

Where did the gospel come from and what places will it reach?

6.4 ACTION TO TAKE FROM A TRUE UNDERSTANDING OF THE GOSPEL

The gospel is God's good news of salvation from sin and evil through King Jesus, a declaration of what God has done. The message transforms those who have truly heard and understood it.

Gordon Fee, in his commentary on the Pastoral Epistles, says that the gospel is at "the heart of everything" for Paul. He describes it as:

"The good news of God's gracious acceptance and forgiveness of sinners, to which the proper response is faith (trusting God that he really does accept sinners) and love toward others".

The next unit puts this reflection into action through training us to share the gospel. But begin to think through what action you need to take:

- It might be through identifying a change that is needed in your **attitudes**. How does the gospel transform your view of yourself or of other people?

- It might be through identifying some **skills** you need to develop to explain these things to others. Are there gaps in your abilities that you need to work on?

- It might be through identifying some gaps in your **knowledge** that you need to fill. Do you have questions about the gospel that you need to have answered?

End this session by in prayer: asking God to act. Use your new understanding of the gospel in prayer for yourself, for your church and for the community you are a part of.